

Captain's Quarters — Brainstorm Session

Distillation

Source: voice-transcribed working session between Jamie and Rich, UE5 asset review + narrative/opening-sequence design. This document extracts the decisions, the strong ideas, the open questions, and the action items — the raw transcript can be discarded once this is filed.

1. Ship Asset Pipeline

The starting fleet, confirmed: three ship tiers — a small starter skiff/sloop, a mid-range **brig**, and a **galleon** (merchant-style upgrade). The brig you're using as reference has cannons on the main deck only (three per side), a lower cargo deck, and no real captain's cabin as modelled — a possible fix is repurposing an unused interior room (currently empty/no material applied — the see-through geometry you noticed is just an unpainted back-face, not a bug) into the captain's space.

A marketplace seller's ship asset library is the current best lead for production-quality hulls. You've already purchased several of his models — the flute, brigantine, schooner, a heavier brig — and have your eye on his **"Ship of the Line"** (currently 50% off, ~£50, and visibly the most detailed of the set: carved detailing, painted rigging, PBR materials). Notably: **he's already built the functionality you need.**

Cannons are fully rigged with bones and animated (fire + reload, montaged).

He has cannonball projectile assets (labelled "projectile cannon," with a splash/water projectile too).

Sound cues already exist per weapon (multiple formats/starts).

Ships are modular — parts (masts, cannons, decoration) can be selected and removed cleanly without breaking the model, meaning you can reconfigure a hull without a rebuild.

Decision made: start development with your existing basic/stylized ship set, and treat the more advanced modular library as a later swap-in once the core loop is proven — don't block early production on repainting/reworking the higher-fidelity set.

Action item flagged in-session: if the project matures, consider contacting this seller directly to scope a **paid commission** for bespoke modular vessels built to your spec, given the quality and volume of his existing catalogue (he has "a lot" of ships beyond the ones purchased).

Repaint note: the higher-fidelity sets use stylized metal materials that would need repainting to match your target palette — flagged as real work but "worth doing" given how much rigged functionality comes for free.

2. The Opening Sequence — this is the strongest idea from the session

You landed on a concrete, well-formed cold-open, and it's worth protecting as-is:

Game starts in near-total darkness. No menu, no HUD, no instructional text. The only prompt is implicit: the player has a match in hand and moves the mouse/stick to strike it.

Ambient audio carries the moment instead of text — boat creaking, a companion's breathing/rowing effort. This does the tutorializing that text would otherwise have to do.

Lighting the match reveals: the player is in a small rowboat, in fog, making out a distant port by a faint light to steer toward. Rowing is deliberately **low-agency** — one or two inputs driving a fixed path — this is a controlled introduction, not open traversal.

Explicit design principle agreed in-session: no on-screen instructional text ("press space," "left click"). Diegetic cues (sound, light, motion) should teach the input instead. Flagged as something you'd actively "dread" seeing on screen.

Doesn't have to be pitch-black throughout — moonlight/dim visibility is acceptable as long as the world is legible but "not well lit."

Verdict from the session, and I'd endorse it: this is a strong, low-cost, high-drama opening. It can reportedly be greyboxed quickly to test whether it "starts feeling like it's coming together" before committing more art time.

A narrative frame discussed for this exact scene (tentative, not locked): the player is set adrift after a mutiny — possibly explicitly modelled on the real *Bounty* mutiny, where Bligh and loyal officers survived days adrift and eventually reached land and regained command. You liked this as a grounding "true story" anchor. The rowboat scene would then be the mutiny's aftermath, not a generic prologue.

3. The Hub Structure — open question, NOT resolved

This is the single biggest unresolved structural question from the session, and it deserves a decision before more downstream design depends on it.

The tension: the game leans toward **extraction-style gameplay** — go out into danger, come back to progress, repair, and unlock more mystery, then go out again. Extraction structures conventionally want a stable home hub. But you both independently worried that **returning to the same home hub repeatedly risks the loop feeling repetitive/"boring."**

The alternative floated: ports are **not** a single home hub, but multiple distinct waypoints along the route, each different, each offering a temporary safe zone with its own quirks (this port has no rudder repair but does have a special cannonball type; that port has different goods, different recruits). This trades a strong "home base" identity for variety, at the cost of a persistent home the player attaches to.

This directly connects to the Captain's Quarters design spec's existing "port" concept (repair / resupply / recruit / discharge / drill) — worth resolving whether Tortuga-style ports are (a) one recurring hub, (b) a rotating cast of distinct ports with different offerings, or (c) both — a true home port plus incidental ports along a given voyage. **Recommend settling this explicitly before more content gets built around it**, since it changes how much unique per-port content you need to author.

4. Narrative Hook — converged on Revenge, with a mutiny/marooning origin

Working through "pillars of story" (character / conflict / plot / setting / theme) live, you landed on:

Setting: established (Age of Sail, the world you already have).

Character: roughed in via the mutiny/marooning origin above.

Conflict / motive: revenge was the strongest candidate discussed — simple, broadly relatable, gets a player invested immediately ("let's go get them"), and gives an in-fiction reason to keep sailing toward danger. Explicitly preferred over a "lost lover" framing, though that was raised as an alternative and isn't fully discarded.

The mutiny concept ties revenge, the marooning origin, and the opening sequence together into one coherent throughline: mutinied against → set adrift → make it back → reclaim a ship → hunt the ones who wronged you. This is a strong, low-overhead spine — worth locking in.

A secondary, optional narrative system floated (not committed): recurring personal side-threads picked up in ports — e.g., an NPC's missing son who went to sea with privateers — where the player might later encounter that exact person/ship out at sea and face a consequential choice (recruit them, let them go, or be the one who sinks their ship without knowing who they were). Flagged as something with strong emotional hook potential ("my decision had a real negative impact") but genuinely additional scope — **explicitly noted in-session as "a lot of work" and not yet worth committing to.**

Explicitly discussed and set aside: faction selection at game start (Navy / privateer-with-letters-of-marque / full pirate) as a way to flavour the early game and gate which port/story content the player sees. Interesting, but flagged in-session as likely too much authoring overhead for the value it adds — **not recommended for an early build.**

5. Combat Toolkit Findings (from the licensed toolkit demo)

Two concrete, useful findings came out of playing the reference toolkit together:

A real design win worth keeping

The toolkit's "block converts to bonus damage if unused" mechanic — i.e., a defensive resource that would otherwise be wasted is automatically redirected into offense — was called out as **something neither of you had seen elsewhere**, and it was well-liked specifically because it **forces a spend decision rather than allowing a resource to evaporate uselessly**. Worth deliberately considering an equivalent conversion mechanic for CQ (e.g., unused Brace rolling into bonus Volley, or similar) — this is a genuinely good, exportable idea and distinct from anything in the current spec.

A real design failure worth avoiding — and useful precedent

The toolkit's default "mystery" encounter template was diagnosed live as a **double negative**: *"push through and take damage, or go around and gain exhaustion"* — no path offers a clean win, and worse, a player who commits to either option gets no positive payoff for the risk, which reads as being punished for engaging rather than rewarded for a good decision. This is explicitly the same category of problem already flagged

in the CQ design spec around **mystery encounters needing real, legible decisions rather than lose-lose or hidden-roll dice** — this session independently rediscovered and reconfirmed that principle from a different angle (an external toolkit's bad example rather than your own prototype's). **Treat this as doubly confirmed: mystery/event design must always offer at least one path with a genuine upside, not just a "which flavour of bad" choice.**

6. Player Fantasy / Camera / Presentation Notes

Several presentation ideas worth carrying into implementation:

Cards should visibly drive the deck, not just resolve numbers. Explicit design intent: playing a card should be *seen* — crew bracing, officers taking action, cannons firing — so the player feels like they're **orchestrating the encounter**, not clicking abstracted buttons. This is squarely the same "the world bleeds into the UI" principle already in the CQ Visual & Audio Direction doc — this session reinforces and adds detail to it (specifically: the camera should react to what's incoming, e.g. shifting to show an enemy closing on your starboard side before a card resolves).

Crew visibility: ordinary crew as fixed/simple background animation (loading, firing), officers as the crew members who visibly move around the deck — a cheap, readable way to make officers feel distinct from generic crew without extra system cost.

A digetic, non-menu-feeling main menu was explicitly preferred — starting the player in the world (on a dock, at a ship chandler) rather than behind a traditional UI menu screen. Consistent with the opening sequence's no-HUD approach.

Telegraphing philosophy raised but not resolved: how much should the voyage map telegraph what's ahead (e.g., "high chance of combat here") versus leaving it to discovery/trial-and-error? Flagged as an open balance question, not decided.

7. Action Items

Resolve the hub-vs-waypoints structural question (Section 3) before more port content is authored — this is the highest-priority open decision from the session.

Greybox the opening rowboat/match sequence as a standalone test, per the plan discussed — cheap to build, high signal on whether the "no-text, diegetic-only" intro actually lands.

Evaluate an **"unused resource converts to bonus" mechanic** (Section 5) as a possible addition to CQ's combat systems — flagged as a genuinely novel, well-liked idea worth prototyping.

Treat the **mystery/event "no lose-lose" rule** (Section 5) as confirmed policy — already in the CQ spec, now doubly validated; hold the line on it during content authoring.

Decide whether the **mutiny/marooning/revenge throughline** (Section 4) is locked as the narrative spine, or still open — it reads as close to a decision in the transcript but wasn't stated as final.

Keep the **son-searching side-thread system** and **faction selection** in a "someday, not now" bucket — both were explicitly flagged as scope risks in-session; don't let them creep into an early build without a deliberate re-opening of the conversation.

Decide on next steps with the **marketplace ship-asset seller** — continue building on the basic set for now (per the session's own conclusion), but keep the commission idea on the table for when the core loop is

proven.